

P2. Charging the City — an ethnography of the e-rickshaw economy under load shedding

Question. How do battery-rickshaw drivers, garage owners, charging-point operators and local power brokers govern an illegal energy economy? How does the fuel hike redistribute risk and income across that chain?

Design. - **Sites:** 3 neighbourhoods in Dhaka (one core, one peri-urban, one where a crackdown or relocation is active) and 1 district town. - **Methods:** - 4–6 months of participant observation at garages and charging points - 60–80 life-history interviews with drivers, sampled for ex-farmers, ex-RMG workers, returned migrants and women in the business (very rare, so an important case) - driver **daily diaries** (earnings, fares, charging costs, rent, “costs to police or fixers”, hours) over 8 weeks, collected via WhatsApp voice notes, with a small stipend - mapping of charging points to cross-check the reported 48,136 illegal vs 3,300 authorised - **Mixed-method add-on:** a structured survey of 400 drivers at charging points to estimate the share who moved into rickshaws from each prior occupation.

Outputs. An ethnographic paper on informal energy governance, a policy note on legalisation and metering (lever #5 in the README), and a photo-essay (with consent).

Budget. ~\$15–30k (researcher stipend, RA, diaries, transcription, translation).